

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Logical Positivism - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper I, Section A | 32 diagnostics, 7 solved PYQs and 6 original Mains models

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

Logical Positivism - Solved Practice Workbook	3
What this workbook contains	3
How to use it	3
BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION	3
32 original MCQs - 24 core diagnostics and 8 remedial error-targeting drills	3
PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE	20
Practice status and source discipline - read once, applies to every solution below	20
SUPPORTING ROUTED PARTS THAT BEAR ON THIS CLAUSE BUT ARE OWNED ELSEWHERE	28
ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS	29

Logical Positivism - Solved Practice Workbook

Standalone workbook. It reproduces the complete practice apparatus of the Logical Positivism learning package and can be worked without the teaching sessions. Syllabus, verbatim: *Logical Positivism : Verification Theory of Meaning; Rejection of Metaphysics; Linguistic Theory of Necessary Propositions* - UPSC Philosophy Paper I, Section A, item 7. **Evidence discipline:** FACT: doctrine on which the standard sources converge · ANALYSIS: analytical reconstruction for exam use · CAUTION: a live scholarly dispute. Model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys. **Terminology rule:** the English concept leads and the source term follows immediately in parentheses - *scientific conception of the world (wissenschaftliche Weltauffassung)*, *protocol sentence (Protokollsatz)*, *affirmation (Konstatierung)*, *pseudo-statement (Scheinsatz)*, *the nothing nothings (das Nichts nichtet)*, *in logic there are no morals (in der Logik gibt es keine Moral)*. Ayer wrote in English and is quotable as written; Schlick, Carnap, Neurath and Heidegger are quoted in **translation**, and works are cited by author, title and year with German and English publication dates given separately wherever they differ.

What this workbook contains

Component	Count
Original diagnostic MCQs - 24 core plus 8 remedial drills	32
Question-specific option explanations	128
Unique examiner traps	32
Directly owned verified PYQs solved in full, 2018-2025	7
Supporting routed parts that bear on this clause but are owned elsewhere	3
Original solved Mains models - two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks	6

How to use it

1. Attempt the twenty-four core MCQs without notes, then read every option explanation, including those for the options you rejected. The key sequence is **unpatterned** - each answer was fixed independently - so no cycle can be guessed.
2. Attempt the eight remedial drills only after the core set; each targets a confusion that recurs in scripts every year, from Popper's demarcation criterion to the difference between non-cognitivism and subjectivism.
3. Write each PYQ under time before reading its solution, and check your script against the **demand-decoding table** rather than against the model answer's wording.
4. Read the three supporting routed parts for their **boundary notes**: each bears directly on this clause while being owned by another syllabus item, and each carries an explicit statement of what this clause may and may not contribute.
5. Finish with the six original Mains models, two at each mark value, to test the same doctrine at three different lengths.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 original MCQs - 24 core diagnostics and 8 remedial error-targeting drills

Answer placement: each correct option was fixed **independently**, so the key sequence is unpatterned rather than rotated, and no cycle such as ABCD can be used to guess. Options are matched for length, specificity, grammar and visible formatting so that the answer cannot be spotted by shape alone. Every question carries four question-specific option explanations and one unique examiner trap.

Coverage: the twenty-four core questions run across the whole printed clause - *Verification Theory of Meaning; Rejection of Metaphysics; Linguistic Theory of Necessary Propositions* - together with the Circle's membership and manifesto, meaning against truth, cognitive significance, verifiability in principle, the strong and weak senses and their casualties, the 1946 revision and Church's objection, the two routes to pseudo-statement status, *das Nichts nichtet*

and Heidegger's reply, the meaning-knowledge-ontology cascade, the necessity trilemma, tautology against observation, the exhaustive dichotomy, Mill's refutation, universal laws and indirect confirmation, theoretical terms, and the protocol debate with Carnap's mediation and the principle of tolerance. The eight remedial drills attack the confusions that cost marks every year: Popper's demarcation against a criterion of meaning, the provenance of the verification slogan, the truth-conditions/verification-conditions substitution, non-cognitivism against subjectivism, the Frege-Geach embedding problem, the decomposition of the 2020 test sentence, the exact cost of each reply to self-refutation, and the ownership boundary against Topics 08 and 11.

MCQ 1. The Vienna Circle's collective statement

Which one of the following correctly describes the 1929 document *Wissenschaftliche Weltauffassung: Der Wiener Kreis* ("The Scientific Conception of the World: The Vienna Circle")?

- A. It was written by Hahn, Neurath and Carnap and dedicated to Schlick, and states a shared scientific attitude and method rather than a list of doctrines every member signed.
- B. It was written by Schlick alone and dedicated to Hahn, and it states the verification principle in precisely the form that Ayer would later popularise for English readers in his book of 1936.
- C. It was written by Carnap and Waismann and dedicated to Wittgenstein, and states the picture theory as the Circle's official account of meaning.
- D. It was written by Ayer after his visit to Vienna and dedicated to Neurath, and states emotivism as the Circle's official account of value judgements.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the manifesto is a collective document by Hahn, Neurath and Carnap, dedicated to Schlick as the Circle's leader, and announces a shared scientific attitude and a method of logical analysis.
- **B:** Incorrect: Schlick led the Circle but did not author the manifesto, and the sharply formulated criterion associated with Ayer's book belongs to 1936, not to the 1929 document.
- **C:** Incorrect: Waismann recorded conversations with Wittgenstein but did not co-author the manifesto, and the picture theory was never adopted as the Circle's official account of meaning.
- **D:** Incorrect: Ayer attended Circle meetings only in 1932-33, three years after the manifesto, and his emotivism belongs to his own 1936 book.

Examiner trap 1: Attributing the manifesto to Schlick is one of the most frequently repeated errors in this clause. He is the **dedicatee**, not the author, and saying so in four words demonstrates that the candidate has met the document rather than heard about it.

MCQ 2. What the verification principle is a criterion of

Consider the following statements about the verification principle.

1. It determines whether a sentence is true or false.
2. It determines whether a sentence is capable of being true or false.
3. A statement that is empirically false therefore fails the principle.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- A. 1 and 3 only
- B. 1 and 2 only
- C. 2 only
- D. 2 and 3 only

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: both statements it selects are wrong, since the principle settles candidacy for truth rather than truth, and falsity is compatible with passing the test.
- **B:** Incorrect: statement 2 is accurate, but pairing it with statement 1 makes the principle simultaneously a test of meaning and of truth, which is exactly the confusion it is designed to remove.
- **C:** Correct: the principle tests cognitive significance, that is, the capacity to be true or false; "the earth is flat" passes and is false.
- **D:** Incorrect: statement 2 is accurate, but statement 3 reverses the doctrine, since a false empirical statement is the clearest possible example of a **meaningful** one.

Examiner trap 2: The single most valuable sentence available in this clause is that a false empirical claim is fully meaningful. A script that writes it in the opening paragraph has secured the discrimination on which every routed question turns.

MCQ 3. What "cognitively meaningless" does and does not assert

Which one of the following best states what the positivist verdict of cognitive meaninglessness does **not** claim?

- A. It does not claim that the words are unintelligible, that the utterance is worthless, or that expressive, ritual and poetic uses of the sentence are thereby abolished.
- B. It does not claim that the sentence lacks truth-conditions, since the positivist grants truth-conditions and denies only that they can be checked.
- C. It does not claim that the sentence fails the analytic test, since metaphysical sentences are conceded by the positivists to be analytic and are faulted only for lacking any empirical support.
- D. It does not claim that the sentence is grammatically well formed, since the positivist holds that metaphysical sentences violate ordinary grammar.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the verdict is narrow and technical, concerning fact-stating capacity alone, and it leaves expressive, practical and poetic functions untouched.
- **B:** Incorrect: the absence of truth-conditions is precisely what the verdict asserts, so this reverses the doctrine at its centre.
- **C:** Incorrect: metaphysical sentences are held to fail **both** routes, and treating them as analytic would make them necessarily true and factually empty rather than meaningless.
- **D:** Incorrect: such sentences are typically **grammatically impeccable**, which is why the diagnosis appeals to logical form rather than to ordinary grammar.

Examiner trap 3: Glossing "cognitively meaningless" as "gibberish" collapses a technical verdict into an insult and forfeits the boundary that the 2020 part is specifically constructed to test.

MCQ 4. Verifiability in principle

"There are mountains on the far side of the moon", asserted in 1935, is, on the positivist account:

- A. cognitively meaningless in 1935 and cognitively meaningful only after 1959, because on this view the meaning of a sentence depends on the observational technology actually available to the speaker.
- B. cognitively meaningful in 1935, because the observations that would settle it could be specified even though no one was then in a position to make them.
- C. cognitively meaningless at every date, because a statement about an unobserved region can never acquire empirical content on any formulation.
- D. cognitively meaningful at every date, because it is analytic in the sense that its subject-term already contains the predicate.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this confuses verifiability **in practice** with verifiability **in principle**, and would absurdly make a sentence change its meaning when a rocket is built.
- **B:** Correct: the observations can be specified, which is all that verifiability in principle requires; practical inaccessibility is irrelevant to meaning.
- **C:** Incorrect: the region is unobserved but not unobservable in principle, which is exactly the difference between an astronomical claim and "the Absolute is beyond all experience".
- **D:** Incorrect: the sentence is plainly synthetic, since its denial is perfectly coherent and no analysis of "far side of the moon" yields mountains.

Examiner trap 4: Candidates lose this distinction by writing that unverifiable statements are meaningless without the qualifier "in principle", which convicts astronomy along with metaphysics and destroys the criterion's own defence.

MCQ 5. What the strong sense of "verifiable" excludes

Which one of the following classes of statement is **not** excluded by the strong sense of "verifiable"?

- A. Universal empirical laws such as "all metals expand when heated".
- B. Statements about the historical past such as "Caesar crossed the Rubicon".
- C. Statements about the mental states of others such as "she is in pain".
- D. Singular present-tense observation reports such as "this page is white".

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: a universal quantifies over indefinitely many instances, so no finite observation set can conclusively establish it, and it is therefore excluded.
- **B:** Incorrect: the event is not now observable, so it cannot be conclusively established by present observation, and it is excluded on the strong sense.
- **C:** Incorrect: another's experience is not an object of the speaker's observation, so it too fails conclusive establishment.
- **D:** Correct: a singular present-tense report is exactly the case the strong sense was built to accommodate, and it survives while the other three classes do not.

Examiner trap 5: The lesson of the exclusion list is that strong verification kills **science**, not merely metaphysics. A script that names only universal laws has given a third of the casualty list and weakens the dilemma it is trying to establish.

MCQ 6. The cost of adopting the weak sense

The principal objection to the weak sense of "verifiable" is that:

- A. it makes the criterion unable to accommodate statements about the historical past, since present records and traces cannot render a past-tense statement either probable or improbable.
- B. it is so permissive that almost any statement can be connected to some observation through a sufficiently elaborate auxiliary hypothesis, so that metaphysics is readmitted.
- C. it treats analytic statements as empirically verifiable, thereby collapsing the distinction between the two branches of the criterion.
- D. it requires conclusive establishment by a finite observation set, thereby excluding the universal laws it was introduced to protect.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: accommodating past-tense statements through present traces is one of the weak sense's **successes**, not its difficulty.
- **B:** Correct: relevance is cheap, and an auxiliary hypothesis can manufacture an observational consequence for a sentence that has none on its own - the structure Church exploited in 1949.
- **C:** Incorrect: the two branches remain distinct; the weak sense loosens only the second, empirical, branch.
- **D:** Incorrect: conclusive establishment by a finite set is the **strong** sense, and attributing it to the weak sense inverts the pair.

Examiner trap 6: Presenting the two senses as a neutral pair of definitions answers a ten-mark question inside a fifteen-mark slot. The marks lie in the **dilemma**: each sense fails at exactly the task the other performs.

MCQ 7. The revised criterion and its refutation

Which one of the following correctly records the sequence of Ayer's revision and its fate?

- A. Ayer adopted the weak sense in 1936, replaced it with direct and indirect verifiability conditions in the Introduction to the second edition of 1946, and Church showed in 1949 that the revised criterion admitted statements it was designed to exclude.
- B. Ayer adopted the strong sense of verifiability in 1936, replaced it with the weak sense in the second edition of 1946, and Church showed in that same year that the weak sense wrongly excluded the universal laws of physics from the class of cognitively meaningful statements.
- C. Ayer adopted direct and indirect verifiability in 1936, abandoned them for the weak sense in 1946, and Church showed in 1951 that both formulations were equivalent to Popper's falsifiability.
- D. Ayer adopted the weak sense in 1946, replaced it with conclusive verifiability in the third edition, and Church showed in 1959 that the criterion collapsed into a criterion of truth.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the 1936 text uses the weak sense, the technical direct/indirect machinery appears in the 1946 Introduction, and Church's published objection is 1949.
- **B:** Incorrect: Ayer named and rejected the strong sense as too strict, and Church's objection is three years after the revision rather than contemporaneous with it.
- **C:** Incorrect: the direct/indirect machinery is the 1946 repair, not the 1936 position, and Church never equated the criterion with Popper's falsifiability.
- **D:** Incorrect: the weak sense belongs to 1936 and conclusive verifiability was never adopted; the dates and the direction of revision are both reversed.

Examiner trap 7: Merging the revision with its refutation loses a date-mark that costs one clause to secure. Write **1936 weak, 1946 revision, 1949 Church** and the chronology is closed.

MCQ 8. The exact strength of the verdict on metaphysics

On the positivist account, "the Absolute is beyond time" is best described as:

- A. false, because no observation supports it and an unsupported existential claim is counted as false by default.
- B. probably false, because the balance of scientific evidence tells against timeless entities.
- C. neither true nor false, because it has no truth-conditions and is therefore not a statement at all.
- D. true but uninformative, because it is analytic in the way that tautologies are analytic.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: falsity presupposes truth-conditions, which is precisely what the positivist says the sentence lacks; and no default rule assigns falsity to unsupported claims.
- **B:** Incorrect: assigning a probability presupposes that the sentence is a hypothesis with evidential bearings, which the diagnosis denies.
- **C:** Correct: the sentence has the grammatical form of an assertion without its logical function, so it receives no truth-value and is classified as a pseudo-statement.
- **D:** Incorrect: analytic truths are true by the meanings of their terms; nothing in the meanings of "Absolute" and "time" yields this sentence, and the positivist denies "Absolute" any criterion of application.

Examiner trap 8: "Positivists showed metaphysics to be false" is visible in the first two lines of a script and is fatal. The verdict is heavier than falsity and is stated as *not false, not unproven, not a statement*.

MCQ 9. Identifying pseudo-statements

Consider the following statements about how a pseudo-statement is identified.

1. A sentence may fail because a constituent term has no empirical criterion of application.
2. A sentence may fail because individually significant terms are combined so that no truth-conditions result.
3. A sentence may fail because it is grammatically ill formed and therefore unreadable.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- A. 1 and 3 only
- B. 1 and 2 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: statement 1 is accurate, but statement 3 misstates the diagnosis, since the sentences in question are typically grammatically impeccable.
- **B:** Correct: Carnap's 1932 analysis gives exactly these two routes - a term without a criterion of application, and an illicit combination of significant terms.
- **C:** Incorrect: statement 2 is accurate, but statement 3 again confuses the ordinary grammar of the sentence with its logical form.
- **D:** Incorrect: including statement 3 would make the diagnosis depend on readability, which would leave "Caesar is a prime number" and "the soul is immortal" untouched.

Examiner trap 9: Offering one route only leaves half the examples unexplained: route 1 alone cannot handle "Caesar is a prime number", and route 2 alone cannot handle "the soul is immortal". The 2021 part asks *how one identifies*, which is a request for a complete procedure.

MCQ 10. Carnap's analysis of Heidegger's sentence

Carnap's objection to *das Nichts nichtet* ("the nothing nothings") is that the sentence:

- A. asserts a proposition that is empirically false, since investigation reveals no such entity as *das Nichts*.
- B. is a poetic utterance mistakenly presented as prose, and should be evaluated by literary rather than logical standards.
- C. treats a logical quantifier as if it were a name and predicates a coined pseudo-verb of the resulting pseudo-name.
- D. relies on a German idiom that has no English equivalent, so that the apparent defect disappears once the sentence is translated correctly.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the charge is not that the sentence makes a false existential claim, but that it makes no claim, since the alleged subject-term is not a referring expression at all.
- **B:** Incorrect: Carnap's objection is structural and would apply equally to an unambiguously assertoric use; reclassifying the sentence as poetry concedes nothing about its logical syntax.
- **C:** Correct: "nothing" is a syncategorematic quantifier, and the sentence is parasitic on the form "something does X" while predicating a verb coined from the pseudo-name.
- **D:** Incorrect: the defect is exhibited in the German original, and the standard English renderings preserve it exactly rather than introducing it.

Examiner trap 10: The phrase must be rendered "**Nothing noths**" or "**the nothing nothings**". "Nothing noughts" is not a rendering of this sentence and must never be written; the error is instantly recognisable to an examiner.

MCQ 11. Heidegger's available reply

Which one of the following correctly states the reply available to Heidegger against Carnap's diagnosis?

- A. That the sentence is analytic, since *das Nichts* is defined as that which nothings, so the predicate is contained in the subject.
- B. That the sentence is empirically verifiable after all, since anxiety is a publicly observable psychological state that can be measured by experimental psychology and by physiological instruments in the laboratory.
- C. That the sentence is a persuasive definition in Stevenson's sense, redirecting attitudes while appearing to report a fact about being.
- D. That *das Nichts* is disclosed in the mood of anxiety (*Angst*), and that the breach of logical grammar is deliberate, since logic itself presupposes the prior disclosure of beings as a whole.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this would make the sentence a trivial tautology and abandon the ontological weight Heidegger places on it, which no reading of his text supports.
- **B:** Incorrect: the reply does not claim empirical verifiability for the sentence; it denies that empirical verifiability is the appropriate standard for it.
- **C:** Incorrect: persuasive definition is Stevenson's metaethical device and has no role in Heidegger's account of the disclosure of *das Nichts*.
- **D:** Correct: the reply concedes the breach of logical grammar and claims that it is intentional, on the ground that logic presupposes a prior disclosure that the sentence attempts to articulate.

Examiner trap 11: Ridiculing the sentence without reporting the reply produces derision rather than assessment. Reporting the reply, and then ruling on it, is what a "critically discuss" directive requires.

MCQ 12. Meaning, knowledge and the nature of things

On the positivist rejection of metaphysics, which one of the following correctly orders the three levels?

- A. The rejection is primarily ontological: metaphysical entities are first shown not to exist, from which it follows both that no knowledge of them is possible and that sentences purporting to describe them are meaningless.
- B. The rejection is primarily epistemological: metaphysical claims are shown to be unknowable, from which it follows that they are meaningless and that their objects do not exist.
- C. The rejection is primarily semantic: metaphysical sentences lack truth-conditions, so the knowledge question is dissolved rather than answered and the existence question is declared ill-formed rather than settled.
- D. The three levels are independent, since the positivist advances a separate argument at each and no ordering among them is either intended or defensible.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: proving non-existence would require a meaningful denial, which needs the very truth-conditions the positivist says are absent, so this reverses the direction of the argument.
- **B:** Incorrect: unknowability presupposes that there is a proposition one fails to know; the positivist's claim is that no proposition has been expressed.
- **C:** Correct: the cut is made at the level of meaning, and the epistemological and ontological consequences follow from it - the first dissolved, the second declared ill-formed.
- **D:** Incorrect: the levels are tightly ordered, since meaning grounds knowledge and knowledge grounds claims about the world, and it is that ordering the 2023 part asks the candidate to display.

Examiner trap 12: Answering "all of them together" without the ordering describes the question instead of answering it. The marked formulation is *all three, through meaning as the root*.

MCQ 13. The problem the linguistic theory is designed to solve

The linguistic theory of necessary propositions is best understood as the positivist solution to which problem?

- A. That logic and mathematics are necessary, known a priori and certain, whereas empiricism holds that all knowledge derives from experience.
- B. That mathematics is indispensable to physics, whereas empiricism holds that only observation statements can enter a scientific theory.
- C. That the analytic and synthetic classes overlap, whereas empiricism requires them to be mutually exclusive if the criterion is to function.
- D. That necessary propositions are unverifiable, whereas the criterion requires every meaningful proposition to be empirically verifiable.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the trilemma between the three properties of necessary truths and the empiricist thesis about the source of knowledge is precisely what the theory resolves.
- **B:** Incorrect: applicability is a **subsequent** difficulty for the theory, not the problem that motivates it, and it arises only after necessity has been made verbal.
- **C:** Incorrect: the positivists assert that the two classes are exhaustive and exclusive; no overlap problem is posed or solved.
- **D:** Incorrect: the criterion is a **disjunction**, so an analytic proposition satisfies it without needing empirical verification at all.

Examiner trap 13: Defining "analytic" and stopping is the standard way this limb is under-marked. State the trilemma first, so that the definition arrives as the **answer to a question** rather than as a piece of vocabulary.

MCQ 14. The 2024 pair

According to the logical positivists, "All objects are either red or not red" and "This page is white" are:

- A. meaningful in the same way, since both are synthetic statements settled by observation of coloured objects.
- B. meaningful in different ways, the first as an analytic tautology of the form $P \sqcap \neg P$ and factually empty, the second as a synthetic statement settled by inspection.
- C. meaningful in different ways, the first as a synthetic generalisation covering every object in the universe and the second as an analytic consequence of the meaning of the word "page".
- D. both cognitively meaningless, the first because it is empty of content and the second because it depends on a private colour-impression.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the first sentence is true under all truth-conditions and rules out no observation whatever, so it cannot be settled by observing anything.
- **B:** Correct: the first passes by the analytic branch and is factually empty; the second passes by the empirical branch and could have been false.
- **C:** Incorrect: this exactly inverts the classification, since the universal quantifier does not make a tautology synthetic and nothing in the meaning of "page" entails a colour.
- **D:** Incorrect: emptiness is not meaninglessness, and colour-reports are the positivists' standard example of an accessible observation statement.

Examiner trap 14: The question as printed asks whether the two are meaningful **in the same way**, so the answer is **no**, with both nevertheless meaningful. A script that answers only "yes, both are meaningful" has replied to a question that was not asked.

MCQ 15. The exhaustive dichotomy

The positivist claim that the analytic/synthetic classification is exhaustive has which one of the following consequences?

- A. That Kant's synthetic a priori is confirmed after all, since analytic truths are shown to be necessary and synthetic truths to be genuinely informative about the world.
- B. That Mill's account of mathematics is confirmed, since arithmetical truths are shown to belong to the synthetic class after all.
- C. That Kant's synthetic a priori is declared incoherent, since there is no third class for a proposition that is both informative and necessary.
- D. That the verification principle becomes redundant, since a two-way classification already sorts every sentence without any further test.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the exhaustiveness claim is directed **against** Kant, and confirming his category would require exactly the third class the positivists deny.
- **B:** Incorrect: Mill's empirical account of arithmetic is rejected, since no experience could refute " $2 + 2 = 4$ " and we do not discover it by counting.
- **C:** Correct: with no third box available, the category of the synthetic a priori is dissolved rather than refuted on Kant's own terms.
- **D:** Incorrect: the classification is the criterion's **content**, not a substitute for it, and it is the criterion that assigns a sentence to a class or to neither.

Examiner trap 15: Writing that the linguistic theory is Kant's synthetic a priori inverts the doctrine at its most heavily tested point. The positivists **deny** the synthetic a priori and make necessity analytic and verbal.

MCQ 16. Why Mill's account fails

The decisive positivist objection to Mill's treatment of " $2 + 2 = 4$ " as an empirical generalisation is that:

- A. arithmetic is used in physics, and an empirical generalisation could not confer the certainty that physical calculation requires.
- B. we do not discover the truth by counting objects, and no experience could refute it, since an apparent counter-instance would be attributed to miscounting or to the creation or destruction of an object.
- C. arithmetic is verified in the strong sense by a finite set of observations on collections of objects, whereas ordinary empirical generalisations admit only the weak, probabilifying sense of verification and never certainty.
- D. Mill's account makes arithmetic analytic, whereas the positivists require necessary truths to be synthetic and known a priori.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: indispensability in physics is a separate difficulty for the positivists themselves, and it is not what shows Mill's account to be absurd.
- **B:** Correct: neither the manner of discovery nor the possibility of refutation fits an empirical generalisation, and the way we treat apparent counter-instances proves the point.
- **C:** Incorrect: arithmetic is not verified by observation at all on the positivist account, since it belongs to the analytic branch and rules out nothing.
- **D:** Incorrect: Mill makes arithmetic **synthetic**, and the positivists make it **analytic**; both halves of the option are reversed.

Examiner trap 16: Mill is the rival **empiricist**, so refuting him is the strongest positive case for the linguistic theory. A script that omits him has argued only against Kant and has left the empiricist alternative standing.

MCQ 17. How a universal law reaches experience

On the positivist account, a universal law such as "all metals expand when heated" acquires empirical significance because:

- A. a sufficiently large finite sample of confirming instances conclusively establishes it, so that the strong sense of "verifiable" turns out to be satisfied by the laws of physics after all, and no revision of the criterion is required.
- B. it is analytic, since "metal" is defined partly in terms of thermal expansion, and analytic statements need no empirical support.
- C. it is falsifiable, since a single counter-instance would refute it, and falsifiability is the positivists' account of empirical meaning.
- D. together with initial conditions and auxiliary assumptions it entails testable predictions, so that successful predictions support the system without conclusively proving the universal.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: no finite sample exhausts an indefinitely large domain, which is exactly why the strong sense had to be abandoned for universals.
- **B:** Incorrect: treating the law as analytic would make it factually empty and would remove precisely the empirical content that physics requires of it.
- **C:** Incorrect: falsifiability is **Popper's** demarcation criterion; he was not a Circle member and did not offer it as an account of meaning.
- **D:** Correct: the law joins a system of hypotheses to observation sentences, and successful predictions support the system without deductively proving the universal.

Examiner trap 17: Attributing falsifiability to the positivists is the commonest single error on this item. Popper called himself the Circle's "official opposition" and held metaphysics to be meaningful.

MCQ 18. Extending the account to metaphysical universals

Can the positivist account of general statements be extended to a metaphysical universal such as "all reality is spiritual"?

- A. No, because such a sentence generates no prediction under any initial conditions and any auxiliary assumptions, and therefore specifies no comparable test.
- B. Yes, because any universal statement can be rendered probable by observations that are consistent with it, and consistency is all the weak sense demands.
- C. No, because metaphysical universals are analytic and therefore belong to the first branch of the criterion rather than the second.
- D. Yes, because the account applies to every statement of unrestricted generality irrespective of its subject matter, and "reality" is as legitimate a subject term as "metal" or "planet".

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: scientific universals have systematic empirical consequences and remain open to confirming and disconfirming evidence, whereas the metaphysical universal specifies no comparable test; the difference is categorical.
- **B:** Incorrect: mere consistency with observation is not evidential relevance, since a sentence consistent with every possible observation is thereby excluded from evidential contact altogether.
- **C:** Incorrect: "all reality is spiritual" is not true by the meanings of its terms, and the positivist denies "spiritual" any criterion of application in this use.
- **D:** Incorrect: unrestricted generality is not the relevant property; what matters is whether the sentence enters into a predictive network at all.

Examiner trap 18: Answering the second half of the 2019 part with a bare "no" forfeits most of the available marks. The reason - **no prediction under any conditions, hence no comparable test** - is the pivot of the whole answer.

MCQ 19. Theoretical terms

On the developed positivist account, a theoretical term such as "electron" acquires empirical significance:

- A. by being explicitly definable as an abbreviation for a finite conjunction of observation statements about the readings of laboratory instruments, so that the term can be eliminated without loss.
- B. through its role in laws, auxiliary assumptions and the testable consequences of a theory-network, rather than by one-to-one correspondence with a single observation.
- C. by being an incomplete symbol that disappears entirely under Russellian analysis, leaving only universals and logical apparatus.
- D. by naming an entity with which the theorist is directly acquainted, in the sense in which one is acquainted with a colour patch.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: explicit definability by a finite conjunction of observation statements is precisely the reductive programme that theoretical terms defeated.
- **B:** Correct: the term gains its content from a network of laws, auxiliaries and consequences, which is why sentence-by-sentence reduction had to be abandoned.
- **C:** Incorrect: incomplete symbols and contextual definition belong to Russell's theory of descriptions in Topic 06, and are not the positivist account of theoretical terms.
- **D:** Incorrect: acquaintance with unobservable entities is exactly what the case excludes, which is what makes theoretical terms a hard case in the first place.

Examiner trap 19: Conceding network-derived content concedes that meaning is not assigned sentence by sentence, which is the criterion's third presupposition. Saying so shows that holistic pressure arose **inside** positivism before Quine formalised it.

MCQ 20. Schlick's affirmations

Schlick's *Konstatierungen* or "affirmations", such as "here now blue", are held to be absolutely certain because:

- A. in them understanding the sentence and verifying it are one and the same act, so that no interval remains in which error could arise.
- B. they are analytic, since the demonstrative "here now" guarantees the truth of whatever predicate is attached to it.
- C. they are confirmed by the agreement of several independent observers, so that intersubjective testing removes every remaining possibility of error.
- D. they are protected by the principle of tolerance, since the language in which they are framed is chosen rather than discovered.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the identity of understanding and verifying leaves no gap for error, which is Schlick's ground for treating affirmations as an unshakeable point of contact with reality.
- **B:** Incorrect: an affirmation is a report of what is presently given and is emphatically not true by the meanings of its terms.
- **C:** Incorrect: intersubjective agreement is **Neurath's** desideratum, and Schlick's certainty is momentary and first-personal rather than public.
- **D:** Incorrect: tolerance is Carnap's doctrine, and it is precisely what undermines Schlick's foundationalism by making the form of the base a matter of choice.

Examiner trap 20: Schlick's own catch must be stated: an affirmation **cannot be written down and preserved**, because recording it yields a hypothesis about a past moment. Its certainty is therefore momentary and unusable in public science.

MCQ 21. Neurath's protocols and the boat

Which one of the following correctly describes Neurath's position in the protocol-sentence debate?

- A. Protocol sentences are incorrigible reports of private experience, and the boat image expresses the security of a base that no revision can reach.
- B. Protocol sentences are analytic conventions, and the boat image expresses the freedom to choose whichever logical framework proves most convenient.
- C. Protocol sentences are conclusively verifiable in the strong sense, and the boat image expresses the completeness of the observational base on which the whole of science is built and from which it can never depart.
- D. Protocol sentences are physicalist, observer- and time-indexed, and fallible like any other sentence, and the boat image expresses the impossibility of rebuilding knowledge from a dry dock.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this states Schlick's foundationalism rather than Neurath's, and the boat image is precisely an image of **anti**-foundationalism.
- **B:** Incorrect: tolerance about frameworks is Carnap's mediating doctrine; Neurath's protocols are empirical reports, not conventions.
- **C:** Incorrect: strong verification of protocols is what Neurath rejects, since he holds that even a protocol may be struck out if it conflicts with the system.
- **D:** Correct: the protocols are public and dated, nothing is sacrosanct, and the sailors must rebuild the ship at sea without ever dismantling it in dry dock.

Examiner trap 21: The boat is **Neurath's**, published in *Erkenntnis* in 1932, with an earlier version in *Anti-Spengler* (1921). Quine used it as the **epigraph** of *Word and Object* (1960); attributing the image itself to Quine is a marked error.

MCQ 22. Carnap's mediation of the protocol debate

Carnap's intervention in "Über Protokollsätze" (1932) held that:

- A. the form of protocol sentences is not a fact to be discovered but a matter of choice of language, which effectively ended foundationalism inside the Circle.
- B. protocol sentences must be phrased in a strictly phenomenalist idiom, since only a report of private experience can supply the incorrigible terminus that verification requires.
- C. protocol sentences must be conclusively verifiable, since otherwise the verification principle would lack the certain base it presupposes.
- D. protocol sentences are unnecessary, since a theory can be confirmed as a whole without any statements functioning as observational termini.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: this is the principle of tolerance applied to the Circle's own foundations, and a chosen base cannot serve as the unshakeable contact Schlick required.
- **B:** Incorrect: Carnap's later commitments run toward a physicalist public language, and in any case his point is that the choice is not settled by discovery.
- **C:** Incorrect: requiring conclusive verification of protocols would simply restate Schlick's position rather than mediate between the two.
- **D:** Incorrect: dispensing with observational termini altogether is a holistic position that belongs to later developments, not to Carnap's 1932 mediation.

Examiner trap 22: The mediation is more damaging than either original position, because a base that is **chosen** cannot ground a criterion advertised as a **discovery** about meaning. That sentence converts a historical note into an argument.

MCQ 23. Schlick's objection to coherentism and its residue

Schlick objected that if truth is coherence with the accepted system, then a consistent fairy-tale is as "true" as science. The accurate assessment of this exchange is that:

- A. Schlick's objection fails, since coherence with a system that includes accepted protocols is by definition sufficient to exclude fairy-tales.
- B. Neurath's reply succeeds, since he shows that logic alone selects the scientific system over any internally consistent rival.
- C. Neurath replies by appealing to the actual encyclopaedic practice of scientists, which leaves the selection sociological rather than epistemic, so the charge is not fully met.
- D. the exchange is inconclusive because neither philosopher published a considered position on the question, and the dispute was settled only later by Ayer's English exposition of the doctrine.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: which protocols count as accepted is exactly what is in dispute, so the reply as stated would beg the question against Schlick.
- **B:** Incorrect: Neurath explicitly denies that logic performs the selection, locating it instead in scientific practice.
- **C:** Correct: the appeal to encyclopaedic practice shifts the ground from epistemology to sociology, a naturalistic consequence Neurath accepted and Schlick found unacceptable.

- **D:** Incorrect: both published in *Erkenntnis* in 1932 and 1934, and Ayer's 1936 book neither addressed nor settled this dispute.

Examiner trap 23: The marks in this exchange lie in the **residue**, not in the objection or the reply. Recording that Schlick's charge is not fully met, and why, is what turns a report of a disagreement into an adjudication of it.

MCQ 24. Internal and external questions

According to Carnap's distinction of 1950, the question "Are there really numbers?", asked about the arithmetical framework as a whole, is:

- A. an internal question, settled by mathematical proof in exactly the way that "is there a prime number greater than 100?" is settled within arithmetic.
- B. a meaningless pseudo-question, indistinguishable in status from "the Absolute is beyond time" and dismissed on the same ground.
- C. a synthetic question, settled by empirical investigation into whether abstract objects are encountered in experience.
- D. not a theoretical question at all, but the practical question whether to adopt the number-language, answered by considerations of usefulness.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: that comparison collapses the distinction, since the internal question is settled by the framework's rules while the external one is asked about the framework itself.
- **B:** Incorrect: Carnap's refinement is precisely that the external question is reclassified as practical rather than simply condemned as meaningless.
- **C:** Incorrect: no empirical investigation bears on whether to adopt a language, and treating the question as synthetic misplaces it inside a framework.
- **D:** Correct: framework adoption is decided pragmatically, on grounds of fruitfulness, simplicity and convenience, and not by truth.

Examiner trap 24: Carnap does **not** abolish ontology. Internal ontological questions remain fully legitimate, and only the framework-level external question is reclassified as a proposal - which is why his anti-metaphysics is stronger than Ayer's.

MCQ 25. Remedial drill - Popper's criterion

Which one of the following correctly states the relation between Popper's falsifiability and the verification principle?

- A. Falsifiability is a criterion of **demarcation** between science and non-science rather than of meaning, and Popper, who called himself the Circle's "official opposition", held metaphysics to be meaningful.
- B. Falsifiability is a repaired version of the verification principle, adopted by the Vienna Circle after Church's objection had shown the earlier formulations to fail.
- C. Falsifiability and verifiability are logically equivalent, since a statement is conclusively falsifiable if and only if its negation is conclusively verifiable, so the dispute between them is merely terminological.
- D. Falsifiability is a criterion of truth, since a statement that survives serious attempts at refutation is thereby shown to be true.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the two answer different questions, and Popper's willingness to treat metaphysics as meaningful, and sometimes as heuristically valuable, marks the difference sharply.
- **B:** Incorrect: Popper was never a member and his 1934 book precedes Church's 1949 objection by fifteen years, so the chronology and the affiliation are both wrong.
- **C:** Incorrect: the logical relation between the two forms does not make a criterion of scientific status into a criterion of meaning, and Popper explicitly denied the identification.

- **D:** Incorrect: Popper insists that surviving refutation is corroboration and not verification, and he denies that it establishes truth.

Examiner trap 25: This drill targets the most common error on the whole clause. Fix it with one clause - **demarcation, not meaning; and metaphysics remains meaningful** - placed wherever Popper is named.

MCQ 26. Remedial drill - the provenance of the slogan

The slogan "the meaning of a proposition is the method of its verification" is most accurately described as:

- A. a proposition of the *Tractatus*, quoted verbatim by the Circle from the 1922 bilingual edition.
- B. the opening sentence of the 1929 Vienna Circle manifesto, drafted by Hahn, Neurath and Carnap.
- C. Ayer's own formulation in *Language, Truth and Logic*, coined by him to replace the vaguer wordings that had been used in the Vienna discussions of the previous decade and never adopted by Schlick.
- D. a formulation associated with the Schlick-Waismann-era verification discussions, whose exact wording varied and which was not a single creed signed by every Circle member.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: no such proposition occurs in the *Tractatus*, whose criterion of sense is depiction and whose account of sense turns on truth-conditions rather than on checking.
- **B:** Incorrect: the manifesto announces a shared scientific attitude and a method of logical analysis, and does not open with this slogan.
- **C:** Incorrect: Ayer's contribution is the strong/weak distinction and the English exposition, not the coining of this formula.
- **D:** Correct: the slogan belongs to the Schlick-Waismann-era discussions and admits of several wordings, so it must not be treated as one exact creed.

Examiner trap 26: Quoting this slogan as a *Tractatus* line is a provenance error that also imports the substantive mistake it conceals - namely that the *Tractatus* was verificationist. Correcting it costs one clause and protects two marks.

MCQ 27. Remedial drill - the substitution the Circle made

The distinctive step by which the Vienna Circle went beyond the *Tractatus* was to:

- A. replace bipolarity with the requirement that every proposition be a truth-function of elementary propositions.
- B. replace the doctrine of showing with a doctrine of saying, so that logical form could itself be stated within a properly regimented scientific language.
- C. replace truth-conditions with verification-conditions, converting a logical requirement on sense into an epistemic requirement of checkability.
- D. replace the analysis of propositions with the analysis of ordinary use, so that meaning became a matter of the circumstances of utterance.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: truth-functional analysis is already the *Tractatus*'s own doctrine and was not something the Circle had to supply.
- **B:** Incorrect: no Circle doctrine converts showing into saying; that debate belongs to the interpretation of the *Tractatus* itself in Topic 06.
- **C:** Correct: the substitution turns a logical condition on sense into an epistemic condition on knowers, and it is what generates the strong/weak dilemma.
- **D:** Incorrect: the analysis of ordinary use is the later Wittgenstein's route, and it is a criticism of the Circle rather than a step taken by it.

Examiner trap 27: The substitution explains **why** universal laws are a problem: their truth-conditions are specifiable while their conclusive verification-conditions are not. Stating the substitution therefore earns two marks at once - historical and diagnostic.

MCQ 28. Remedial drill - non-cognitivism against subjectivism

Which one of the following correctly states what Ayer and Stevenson share and where they differ?

- A. Both hold that "stealing is wrong" reports the speaker's own disapproval, but Ayer treats that report as incorrigible while Stevenson treats it as an ordinary fallible claim about the speaker.
- B. Both hold that "stealing is wrong" is analytic, but Ayer treats it as empty while Stevenson treats it as covertly descriptive of social conventions.
- C. Both hold that "stealing is wrong" is a factual claim about consequences, but they disagree about which consequences are relevant to its truth.
- D. Both deny that "stealing is wrong" reports the speaker's feeling, but Ayer treats it as a pure expression while Stevenson gives it a descriptive as well as an emotive meaning.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: treating the sentence as a report of the speaker's feeling is **subjectivism**, which both reject on the ground that it turns moral disagreement into disagreement about autobiography.
- **B:** Incorrect: neither treats moral sentences as analytic, and doing so would make moral truths knowable by inspecting meanings alone.
- **C:** Incorrect: both are non-cognitivists and deny that such sentences state facts at all, so no disagreement about relevant consequences can arise between them.
- **D:** Correct: the shared commitment is non-cognitivism rather than subjectivism, and the difference lies in Stevenson's two-part account of meaning.

Examiner trap 28: Writing "emotivism says 'X is wrong' means 'I disapprove of X'" states the position **both** philosophers went out of their way to refute. Expression is not report, and getting this right is worth a mark by itself.

MCQ 29. Remedial drill - the embedding problem

The Frege-Geach embedding problem shows that simple emotivism cannot explain:

- A. why moral attitudes are more general and more socially significant than mere personal preferences, such as a distaste for broccoli, with which non-cognitivism appears to classify them together.
- B. how the antecedent of "if lying is wrong, then getting your brother to lie is wrong" can mean the same as the free-standing "lying is wrong", given that the antecedent expresses no attitude.
- C. how moral judgements can change over time, given that attitudes may converge without any proposition becoming true.
- D. why ethical terms carry emotive force at all, given that their descriptive meaning varies with the context of utterance.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is the distinct "moral disapproval against mere distaste" objection, which Stevenson can partly answer by appeal to generality and social function.
- **B:** Correct: in an unasserted context no attitude is expressed, yet the sentence must retain its meaning for the inference to be valid, and expressivism has no account of the unasserted occurrence.
- **C:** Incorrect: this is the moral-progress objection, which Stevenson meets by treating progress as convergence of attitude under fuller belief.
- **D:** Incorrect: the origin of emotive force is explained by Stevenson through dispositions built up by usage, and is not what the embedding problem attacks.

Examiner trap 29: Naming Frege-Geach and stating the unasserted-context point in one sentence lifts an "assess emotivism" answer immediately above average, and no answer to it was available to either Ayer or Stevenson.

MCQ 30. Remedial drill - the 2020 test sentence

In examining "The Soul of Superman is Good" in the light of logical positivism, the fully controlled answer:

- A. declares the sentence false, since Superman is a fictional character, and a fictional character possesses neither a soul nor any moral properties that a predicate of value could correctly report.
- B. declares the sentence analytic, since goodness is part of the very concept of a superhero and the predicate is therefore already contained in the subject, so that no possible observation could ever be relevant to the truth or the falsity of the sentence.
- C. separates the unverifiable subject-term from the non-descriptive value-predicate, concludes that the sentence is cognitively meaningless rather than false, and notes that within a stated fiction-framework a claim about the text would be checkable.
- D. declares the sentence meaningful, since the moral quality of a well-known fictional character can be established empirically by surveying the attitudes that readers in fact express towards him.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: falsity presupposes truth-conditions, and the whole point of the diagnosis is that this sentence supplies none.
- **B:** Incorrect: no analysis of "superhero" yields goodness, and treating the sentence as analytic would make it necessarily true and factually empty.
- **C:** Correct: the two failures are independent and must be handled separately, and the fiction-framework qualification prevents the overreach of condemning every fictional sentence.
- **D:** Incorrect: a survey establishes what readers feel, not that the character is good, so this substitutes a sociological claim for the evaluative one.

Examiner trap 30: The marks in this ten-mark part are in the **split**: an unverifiable subject-term is one failure and a non-descriptive value-predicate is another. A script that treats the sentence as failing in a single undifferentiated way has done half the work.

MCQ 31. Remedial drill - the replies to self-refutation

Which one of the following correctly pairs a reply to the self-refutation objection with its cost?

- A. Reply: the principle is a meta-linguistic rule. Cost: the reply concedes that metaphysical sentences are meaningful after all, since rules and metaphysical assertions occupy exactly the same linguistic level.
- B. Reply: the principle is a recommendation about how to use "meaningful". Cost: it retreats from a discovery about meaning to a policy, so that it is no longer clear why anyone must accept it.
- C. Reply: the principle is analytic of the ordinary concept of meaning. Cost: it becomes empirically testable by surveying speakers, and such surveys refute it.
- D. Reply: the principle is synthetic and verifiable by the success of science. Cost: it thereby becomes a criterion of truth rather than of meaning.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the meta-linguistic reply does not license metaphysics; its actual cost is that the demand for justification simply recurs at the meta-level.
- **B:** Correct: the proposal reply avoids straightforward contradiction, but a proposal can be declined, so the metaphysician's refusal ceases to be a demonstrable error.
- **C:** Incorrect: the positivist reply appeals to the concept of meaning **they propose**, not to ordinary usage, and its cost is circularity rather than empirical refutation.

- **D:** Incorrect: no positivist claimed the principle was verified by the success of science, and the option confuses a defence of the criterion with an instance of its application.

Examiner trap 31: Self-refutation deserves two sentences, not a paragraph. Rank it **fourth** behind the strong/weak fork, the protocol debate and the analyticity attack, because the first two are internal and therefore cannot be dismissed as external hostility.

MCQ 32. Remedial drill - ownership and the plural decline

Which one of the following statements about the decline of logical positivism is accurate?

- A. The movement was destroyed by the self-refutation objection alone, which is why the later criticism of Popper, Quine and the ordinary-language philosophers added nothing of independent philosophical significance to the case against it.
- B. The movement was destroyed by the later Wittgenstein, whose account of meaning as use is the positive doctrine the Circle had been seeking.
- C. The movement was destroyed by Popper, whose falsifiability criterion replaced verification as the accepted account of empirical meaning.
- D. The movement declined under several pressures at once - scientific generalisations, the disputed protocol base, theory-dependence and the attack on analyticity, as well as self-application - and no single critic ended it.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: self-application admits a serviceable reply, and the internal difficulties over laws and protocols did more damage than the classic charge.
- **B:** Incorrect: the later Wittgenstein rejects any single criterion of meaning whatever, so his account is not the doctrine the Circle sought, and it is owned by Topic 08.
- **C:** Incorrect: falsifiability was never adopted as an account of meaning, and Popper regarded metaphysics as meaningful rather than as disqualified.
- **D:** Correct: the pressures were plural and partly internal, which is why the honest verdict describes a structural collapse rather than a single decisive refutation.

Examiner trap 32: Naming one critic as having "destroyed" the movement invites the examiner to ask about the others. Rank the pressures instead, and state what survived - the difference-argument as a heuristic of significance, and the permanent separation of criteria of meaning, of truth and of scientific status.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Practice status and source discipline - read once, applies to every solution below

Every model answer here is independent learner practice and is **never** an official UPSC key; UPSC publishes no descriptive model answers for Philosophy Paper I. Question wording is reproduced exactly as printed in the official papers, including the printed anomalies the repository ledger flags. The 2018, 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024 and 2025 Paper I texts are held locally, and the English wording of every part below - including the three supporting parts owned by other topics - follows the repository's verified Western Philosophy PYQ ledger. Works are cited by **author, title and year**, with German and English publication dates given separately wherever they differ. Interpretive disputes - whether Neurath's coherentism preserved empiricism, whether the move to confirmation theory was continuity or capitulation, and whether Carnap's internal/external distinction survives Quine's attack - are flagged as contested rather than settled.

Answer-length convention used throughout this package. UPSC Philosophy Paper I parts are written longer than General Studies answers. The working bands used here are **10 marks - about 150 to 220 words**, **15 marks - about 250 to 330 words**, and **20 marks - about 330 to 400 words**. Every solution below sits inside its declared band, and the demand decoding, the verdict heading and the "why this earns marks" notes are teaching apparatus that sit **outside** the timed word count.

Coverage. ANALYSIS: Corpus signal: this clause owns **7 of 112** Western Philosophy question-parts in the 2018-2025 corpus, with **2022 the only year without an owned part**. All seven are solved in full below, followed by **three supporting routed parts** that bear directly on this clause while being owned by Topics 08 and 11, and **six original solved Mains models**, two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks. The internal distribution is worth knowing before the exam: the **verification theory** is tested directly in 2018 and 2025, the **rejection of metaphysics** in 2018, 2021 and 2023, the **linguistic theory of necessary propositions** in 2024, **general statements and scientific language** in 2018 and 2019, and **value language under the criterion** in 2020. A candidate who prepares the criterion but not the third limb has prepared about two-thirds of the clause.

Solved PYQ 1 · 2018 · Q3(b) · 15 marks

Question: How do the logical positivists show that metaphysical sentences are meaningless? Can their verification theory of meaning account for the meaningfulness of all scientific sentences? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"How do they show...? Can it account...? Discuss." - a method, then a tested extension, then a verdict
Core issue	Whether the instrument that excludes metaphysics also admits science
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the criterion and diagnosis briefly, then the scientific hard cases, then the price
Ideal thesis	The exclusion works, the admission works only in a weakened form, and the weakening is the same event
Non-negotiables	Meaning against truth; the two routes; universal laws; theoretical terms; the "at the cost of the boundary" verdict

Independent model answer

Thesis. The positivists exclude metaphysics by a criterion of cognitive significance, and they can admit scientific sentences only by loosening that criterion until it can no longer do the excluding - so the two halves of this question have a single answer.

How the exclusion is shown. A sentence carries cognitive meaning only if it is analytic or empirically verifiable. Metaphysical sentences fail both, and Carnap's "The Elimination of Metaphysics through Logical Analysis of Language" (1932) supplies the diagnosis in two routes: a term such as "the Absolute" for which no empirical criterion of application exists, and a combination such as *das Nichts nichtet*, in which a logical quantifier is treated as a name and a pseudo-verb predicated of it. **ANALYSIS:** The verdict is not falsity but absence of truth-conditions - Ayer's metaphysical sentence "purports to express a genuine proposition, but does not".

The scientific test. On the **strong** sense of "verifiable" - conclusive establishment by a finite observation set - universal laws, statements about the past and statements about other minds are all excluded, which convicts physics along with metaphysics. On the **weak** sense the sentences return: "all metals expand when heated" reaches experience through initial conditions and auxiliary assumptions that yield testable predictions; the past is handled through present traces; and "electron" acquires significance through its role in a theory-network rather than by correspondence with one observation.

Verdict. **ANALYSIS:** The account of science succeeds, but the relation is indirect, system-dependent and no longer sentence-by-sentence, and Church showed in 1949 that Ayer's 1946 repair readmitted what it excluded. **ANALYSIS:** So verification can account for the meaningfulness of scientific sentences only in a form so loose that it can no longer exclude metaphysics - which is the school's central difficulty rather than an incidental one.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the question has two halves with one answer. Say so in the thesis, and the script acquires an argument instead of two descriptions.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: thesis two lines; exclusion five; scientific test six; verdict four.

- **Structure:** state the single answer -> the criterion and diagnosis -> the hard cases -> the price.

- **Doctrine:** cognitive significance; two routes to pseudo-statement status; strong against weak.
- **Evidence:** Carnap 1932; Ayer 1936 and the 1946 Introduction; Church 1949.
- **Distinction:** meaninglessness against falsity; in principle against in practice.
- **Criticism:** the loosening that saves science is the loosening that fails to exclude.

Solved PYQ 2 · 2019 · Q2(a) · 20 marks

Question: How do the logical positivists account for the meaning of general statements? Can the same account be applied to metaphysical statements? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"How do they account...? Can the same account...? Discuss." - an account, an extension test, a reasoned refusal
Core issue	Whether the machinery that rescues universal laws also rescues metaphysical universals
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: the problem, the machinery, three further hard cases, the refusal, and the residual cost
Ideal thesis	Scientific universals are partially cashable; metaphysical universals present no bill at all
Non-negotiables	Finite observation sets; the prediction route; the categorical difference; the auxiliary-hypothesis counter-pressure

Independent model answer

Thesis. The positivists account for general statements by abandoning conclusive verification for indirect, system-level confirmation, and that account cannot be extended to metaphysical statements - not because they are harder to test, but because they enter no predictive relation whatever.

The problem. A universal empirical law quantifies over indefinitely many instances, so no finite observation set can conclusively establish it. On the strong sense of "verifiable" the laws of science are therefore meaningless, which is an unacceptable result.

The machinery. Ayer's weak route asks only that some possible observations be relevant - that they render the statement probable or improbable. A law joins a system of hypotheses to observation sentences: law plus initial conditions plus auxiliary assumptions entails a testable prediction, and successful predictions support the system without deductively proving the universal. Later confirmation theory develops this into degrees of evidential support. **WRONG:** Potential falsification is Popper's contrasting demarcation proposal and is not the positivists' definition of meaning.

Three further hard cases. Historical statements are assessed through present records and causal traces; other-minds statements through publicly observable behaviour, language and explanatory theory; theoretical entities through their role in testable scientific systems. **ANALYSIS:** Each route is indirect and theory-dependent, which weakens simple sentence-by-sentence reduction without making the statements meaningless.

The extension refused. "All reality is spiritual" specifies no observation that would count for or against it, not even in principle. Under no initial conditions and with no auxiliaries does it yield a prediction, so the confirmation machinery has nothing to operate on. **ANALYSIS:** General scientific statements have systematic empirical consequences; metaphysical universals specify no comparable test, and the difference is categorical rather than one of degree.

Verdict. **CAUTION:** The refusal is principled but not wholly secure: weakening verification to save science does risk admitting metaphysics through elaborate auxiliaries, and the positivist reply - that public predictive integration differs from insulation from evidence - is reasonable without being conclusive. **ANALYSIS:** The honest verdict is that the account rescues science at the cost of a boundary it can defend but no longer draw sharply.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the second half is where the marks concentrate, and it must be answered with a **reason** rather than a verdict. "No comparable test" is the phrase to write.

Exam-length execution - 20 marks, about 330 to 400 words: thesis two lines; problem three; machinery six; three hard cases four; refusal five; verdict four.

- **Structure:** state the account's shape -> the problem -> the machinery -> the further cases -> the refusal -> the residual cost.
- **Doctrine:** weak verification; prediction from law plus conditions plus auxiliaries; degrees of confirmation.
- **Evidence:** "all metals expand when heated"; Caesar's crossing; other minds; the electron.
- **Distinction:** systematic empirical consequences against no test at all.
- **Criticism:** the auxiliary-hypothesis counter-pressure, conceded rather than concealed.

Solved PYQ 3 · 2020 · Q1(e) · 10 marks

Question: "The Soul of Superman is Good." Critically examine the above statement in the light of logical positivism.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Critically examine... in the light of" - apply the doctrine, then assess the application
Core issue	Two independent failures in one short sentence
Scope boundary	Ten marks: criterion, subject-term, value-predicate, verdict, one qualification
Ideal thesis	The sentence fails twice over and is meaningless rather than false
Non-negotiables	The split; "cognitively meaningless, not useless"; the fiction-framework qualification

Independent model answer

Thesis. On the positivist criterion this sentence fails twice - once in its subject and once in its predicate - and the correct verdict is that it is cognitively meaningless rather than false.

The criterion applied. A sentence carries cognitive meaning only if it is analytic or empirically verifiable. This sentence is neither.

The subject-term. "The Soul of Superman" supplies no empirical criterion of application: "soul" has none in the required sense, and the bearer is fictional. On Carnap's first route to pseudo-statement status, a sentence containing such a term essentially can acquire no truth-conditions.

The value-predicate. On Ayer's account in *Language, Truth and Logic* (1936) a value term adds no factual content; it evinces approval and may evoke it. The predicate is therefore expressive rather than descriptive, and it cannot supply the truth-conditions the subject-term has failed to provide.

Verdict and qualification. ANALYSIS: The sentence is cognitively meaningless - not false, and not merely unproven. ANALYSIS: But the verdict is narrow: it does not show the words unintelligible, and within an explicitly stated fiction-framework a related claim, that the character is portrayed as good in the text, would be perfectly checkable. WRONG: Nothing here licenses the claim that every fictional or evaluative sentence is meaningless in every use.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the split between subject and predicate is the whole of the marks. A single undifferentiated verdict does half the work.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 220 words: thesis one line; criterion two; subject three; predicate three; verdict and qualification four.

- **Structure:** verdict first -> criterion -> subject -> predicate -> qualification.
- **Doctrine:** cognitive significance; route one; emotive use of value terms.
- **Evidence:** Carnap 1932's first route; Ayer 1936, ch. 6.
- **Distinction:** cognitively meaningless against false, and against useless.
- **Criticism:** the fiction-framework case, which bounds the verdict honestly.

Solved PYQ 4 · 2021 · Q2(b) · 15 marks

Question: What according to Logical Positivists are "pseudostatements"? How does one identify "pseudostatements"? Critically discuss with examples.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"What are...? How does one identify...? Critically discuss with examples." - definition, procedure , examples, assessment
Core issue	The identification procedure, not a list of condemned sentences
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: definition, two routes, four graded examples with a control, one live objection
Ideal thesis	A pseudo-statement has the grammar of an assertion without its logical function, and is identified by a two-route test
Non-negotiables	Both routes; a meaningful control case; the correct rendering of <i>das Nichts nichtet</i> ; Heidegger's reply

Independent model answer

Definition. A pseudo-statement (*Scheinsatz*) is a string possessing the grammatical form of a declarative sentence without the logical function of one: it has no truth-conditions, and therefore no truth-value. **ANALYSIS:** It is not false; falsity presupposes exactly what it lacks.

The identification procedure. First ask whether the sentence is analytic, true or false by the meanings and rules of its terms. If it is, it is meaningful and factually empty. If not, ask whether any possible observation could count for or against it; if some could, it is meaningful and synthetic. If neither holds, diagnose the failure by one of Carnap's two routes (*Erkenntnis*, 1932): a constituent **term** has no empirical criterion of application, or individually significant terms are **combined** so that no truth-conditions result.

Worked examples. "The soul is immortal" fails by the first route, since "soul" has no criterion of application. "Caesar is a prime number" fails by the second: every word is significant, the grammar is impeccable, and no verification procedure applies. Heidegger's *das Nichts nichtet* - "the nothing nothings" - is the paradigm of the second route, committing a double violation by treating a logical quantifier as a name and predicating a coined verb of it. **FACT:** By contrast "electrons have negative charge" is **meaningful**, though testable only indirectly through a predictive theoretical network - a control case that shows the test discriminates rather than merely condemns.

Critical assessment. **CAUTION:** Heidegger's available reply is that *das Nichts* is disclosed in the mood of anxiety (*Angst*), and that the breach of logical grammar is deliberate because logic itself presupposes the prior disclosure of beings as a whole. **ANALYSIS:** More seriously, the test inherits every weakness of the criterion behind it: on the strong sense it convicts science, and on the weak sense an auxiliary hypothesis can manufacture the relevance it demands.

Verdict. **ANALYSIS:** The procedure is genuinely diagnostic - it explains how such sentences are generated - but it establishes that a sentence fails **this** criterion, not that no such sentence could ever be significant.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "how does one identify" is a request for a **procedure**. Number the steps, then run examples through them.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: definition two lines; procedure four; examples six; assessment four; verdict two.

- **Structure:** define -> procedure -> graded examples including a control -> objection -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** *Scheinsatz*; the two routes; the analytic/empirical filter.
- **Evidence:** Carnap 1932; Heidegger 1929; the four worked sentences.
- **Distinction:** meaningless against false; route one against route two.
- **Criticism:** Heidegger's reply, and the criterion's own instability.

Solved PYQ 5 · 2023 · Q3(a) · 20 marks

Question: Does the rejection of metaphysics as proposed by Logical Positivists relate to problem of meaning or problem of knowledge or nature of things or all of them together? Discuss with suitable examples.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	A disjunctive question with an "all together" option - the answer must order the three, not merely accept the last
Core issue	Which level is primary, and how the other two follow from it
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: three levels, worked examples, the connective argument, assessment, ruling
Ideal thesis	All three, but through meaning as the root
Non-negotiables	The dissolution of the knowledge question; the refusal to deny existence; Carnap's refinement; the criterion's own vulnerability

Independent model answer

Thesis. The rejection is primarily a rejection at the level of **meaning**, and it is precisely because the cut is made there that it has consequences for knowledge and for ontology. The correct answer is therefore "all of them together", but with meaning as the root.

Meaning. The verification principle declares metaphysical sentences pseudo-propositions: they fail both the analytic and the empirical route and so possess no truth-conditions. "The Absolute is perfect" and *das Nichts nichtet* are the standard examples, the second diagnosed by Carnap in 1932 as treating a quantifier as a name. ANALYSIS: The rejection is linguistic: the **sentences** are defective, not merely the **evidence** for them or the **objects** they purport to describe.

Knowledge. Because the sentences are meaningless, no knowledge-claim about them can arise. One can neither know nor fail to know what is not even a proposition. ANALYSIS: The epistemological question is therefore **dissolved** rather than answered - a stronger and stranger result than agnosticism, which presupposes a proposition whose truth-value is undetermined.

Nature of things. Positivists do not assert that metaphysical objects do not exist; that would be a meaningful denial requiring the very truth-conditions declared absent. They hold that the **question** of their existence is ill-formed. ANALYSIS: Ontological commitment is refused at the level of purported factual discourse, not established by proving non-existence - which is also why Ayer's position is not atheism.

All together. The three are connected in one direction: meaning grounds knowledge, and knowledge grounds claims about the world. By cutting at the level of meaning, positivism simultaneously eliminates pseudo-knowledge and pseudo-ontology without arguing separately at either level.

Assessment. ANALYSIS: The strength is a powerful housecleaning that forces precision on philosophical claims. ANALYSIS: The weaknesses are three: the criterion fails its own test unless read as a proposal, which weakens its force; the Circle could not agree on the observational base the criterion presupposes, as the Schlick-Neurath protocol dispute of 1932-35 shows; and Carnap's own later refinement replaced blanket dismissal with the internal/external distinction of 1950, under which framework-internal ontology remains fully legitimate. CAUTION: Quine later contests that distinction without ending the debate by fiat.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: It is all three, through meaning as the root - and the developed Carnapian form, which reclassifies rather than condemns, is the version worth defending.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the question offers four options and the marks lie in **ordering**, not in selecting. "All three, through meaning as the root" is the thesis sentence.

Exam-length execution - 20 marks, about 330 to 400 words: thesis two lines; meaning five; knowledge four; nature of things five; connection three; assessment five; verdict two.

- **Structure:** rule first -> three levels in order -> the connective argument -> assessment -> ruling.

- **Doctrine:** pseudo-proposition; dissolution against answering; ill-formed against false.
- **Evidence:** Carnap 1932; the protocol dispute 1932-35; Carnap 1950.
- **Distinction:** dissolution against agnosticism; reclassification against condemnation.
- **Criticism:** self-application, the disputed base, and the doctrine's own development.

Solved PYQ 6 · 2024 · Q3(b) · 15 marks

Question: Is the sentence "All objects are either red or not red" meaningful in the same way as "This page is white" is, according to the logical positivists? Discuss with arguments.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	A yes/no question with "discuss with arguments" - the answer is no , and the argument is the two branches
Core issue	Two kinds of meaningfulness, not one
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: classify both, explain each branch, contrast with what fits neither, one pressure
Ideal thesis	Both meaningful, by different branches; the first is empty, the second is factual
Non-negotiables	The form $P \sqcup \neg P$; "no observation could refute it because it is empty"; the metaphysical contrast

Independent model answer

Thesis. No. Both sentences are meaningful on the positivist criterion, but by different branches of it: the first is an analytic tautology and factually empty, the second is a synthetic statement settled by observation.

The first sentence. "All objects are either red or not red" has the form $P \sqcup \neg P$. Its truth depends only on the meanings of the logical constants "or" and "not", not on any empirical fact about colour. It is true under all truth-conditions, and no observation could refute it - precisely because it says nothing that an observation could bear on. It is therefore **meaningful as a logical truth**, necessary, a priori and **empty of factual content**.

The second sentence. "This page is white" is synthetic. It is meaningful because it is verifiable: one can look at the page and confirm or disconfirm it. Its truth depends on an observable fact and it **could be false** - the page might be blue. It carries factual content precisely because it excludes possibilities.

The argument for the difference. The criterion of cognitive significance is a **disjunction**: a sentence is meaningful if it is analytic **or** empirically verifiable. The two sentences satisfy different disjuncts, and the two kinds of significance are not interchangeable. The tautology is meaningful because it is logically valid; the empirical statement is meaningful because it is testable. ANALYSIS: This is also what makes the third case instructive: "the Absolute is beyond time" satisfies **neither** disjunct and is a pseudo-statement.

Assessment. ANALYSIS: The classification is only as secure as the analytic/synthetic boundary on which it rests, and Quine argues in "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (1951) that analyticity cannot be non-circularly defined. ANALYSIS: That pressure does not restore the metaphysical case, but it does show that the two-branch account is a commitment rather than an obvious truth.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Both are meaningful; neither in the same way as the other; and the contrast between them exhibits the whole criterion in two sentences.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the question asks "in the same way", so a script that merely establishes that both are meaningful has answered a different question. Answer **no**, then justify each branch separately.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: thesis two lines; first sentence four; second sentence four; the argument four; assessment three; verdict one.

- **Structure:** answer no -> classify each -> state the disjunction -> add the excluded third case -> assess.
- **Doctrine:** analytic against synthetic; tautology; factual emptiness.
- **Evidence:** the form $P \sqcup \neg P$; the blue-page counterfactual; the metaphysical control.

- **Distinction:** meaningful-and-empty against meaningful-and-factual.
- **Criticism:** Quine's pressure on analyticity, bounded to one clause.

Solved PYQ 7 · 2025 · Q3(b) · 15 marks

Question: Present an exposition of the verification theory of meaning as propounded by the logical positivists. In this context also differentiate between the "strong" and the "weak" sense of the word "verifiable".

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Present an exposition... also differentiate" - a full statement first, then a differentiation, then an assessment
Core issue	The criterion in both its licensing and its excluding halves, and the fork inside it
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: exposition, the two senses with casualties, the revision history, a graded verdict
Ideal thesis	The criterion is a test of candidacy for truth, and the two senses are the horns of a dilemma
Non-negotiables	Meaning against truth; the biconditional; conclusive against probabilifying; Ayer's attribution; 1946 and 1949

Independent model answer

Thesis. The verification theory is a criterion of cognitive significance, not of truth, and the strong and weak senses of "verifiable" are not two options but the two horns of a dilemma the school never escaped.

Exposition. The Vienna Circle - Schlick, Carnap and Neurath, with Ayer as its English expositor - held that a sentence is cognitively meaningful **if and only if** it is either analytic, true solely by the meanings of its terms, or empirically verifiable, in that some possible experience bears on its truth. Read one way the biconditional licenses logic, mathematics and science; read the other it excludes everything else as pseudo-statement. **ANALYSIS:** The test asks not whether a sentence is true but whether it says anything: "the earth is flat" is false and fully meaningful, while "the Absolute is beyond time" receives no truth-value. **ANALYSIS:** Verifiability is required **in principle**, not in practice, which is why claims about the far side of the moon were meaningful before spaceflight.

Strong and weak. In the **strong** sense a statement is verifiable only if a finite set of observations can **conclusively establish** its truth. This excludes metaphysics cleanly, but also universal laws, the past and other minds - it kills science. In the **weak** sense it is enough that some possible observations be **relevant**, rendering the statement probable or improbable. This saves scientific generalisations, but is so permissive that an auxiliary hypothesis can connect almost any sentence to some observation, so metaphysics creeps back. **ANALYSIS:** The vocabulary is specifically Ayer's; Circle members offered differing formulations.

The repair and its failure. Ayer adopted the weak sense in *Language, Truth and Logic* (1936) and replaced it with technical direct and indirect verifiability conditions in the 1946 Introduction; Church showed in 1949 that the revision admitted what it had excluded.

Verdict. **ANALYSIS:** The principle remains historically decisive against obscurity, but no formulation survives its own demands, and the school's serious work migrated to confirmation and testability at the cost of the sharp boundary.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "exposition" means both halves of the biconditional, not just the exclusion; "differentiate" means the dilemma, not a pair of definitions.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: thesis two lines; exposition six; strong and weak six; repair two; verdict two.

- **Structure:** frame -> exposition with the biconditional -> the two senses with their casualties -> 1946 and 1949 -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** cognitive significance; the disjunction; in principle against in practice.
- **Evidence:** "the earth is flat"; the far side of the moon; Ayer 1936, 1946; Church 1949.
- **Distinction:** conclusive establishment against probabilifying relevance.

- **Criticism:** the fork is internal, and the repair failed.

SUPPORTING ROUTED PARTS THAT BEAR ON THIS CLAUSE BUT ARE OWNED ELSEWHERE

ANALYSIS: **Boundary note.** The three parts below are printed in the 2018-2025 corpus and are routinely mistaken for Logical Positivism questions because their subject matter presses directly on this clause. Each is **owned by another syllabus item**, and each is given here with an explicit statement of what this clause may and may not contribute. None is counted among the seven owned parts.

Supporting part A · 2019 · Q1(e) · 10 marks · owned by Topic 11, Quine and Strawson

Question: Explain Quine's arguments against synthetic-analytic distinction.

What this clause contributes. ANALYSIS: The **target**. The linguistic theory of necessary propositions requires the analytic/synthetic classification to be exhaustive and sharp, and the verification principle's first disjunct is stated in terms of analyticity. This clause supplies what Quine is attacking: necessity as verbal, tautologies as factually empty, and the denial of the synthetic a priori.

What this clause may not do. WRONG: It may not supply Quine's positive case - the circle of synonymy, interchangeability and semantical rules, the rejection of reductionism, or the web-of-belief picture. Those belong to Topic 11 and constitute the whole substance of the answer.

Boundary sentence for the exam. "The distinction Quine attacks is the one on which logical positivism rests its account of necessity, which is why his argument is a threat to the school rather than an internal correction of it."

Supporting part B · 2024 · Q4(c) · 15 marks · owned by Topic 11, Quine and Strawson

Question: Explain the nature of the two dogmas that Quine refers to in his paper 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism'.

What this clause contributes. ANALYSIS: The **two dogmas are positivism's two pillars**, and naming them as such shows the candidate understands the target. The first dogma is belief in a fundamental cleavage between analytic and synthetic truths, which underwrites the linguistic theory of necessary propositions; the second is reductionism, the belief that each meaningful statement is equivalent to some construction upon terms referring to immediate experience, which underwrites the sentence-by-sentence criterion of significance.

What this clause may not do. WRONG: It may not develop Quine's arguments, his confirmation holism, or his conclusion that the boundary between speculative metaphysics and natural science is blurred. Those are Topic 11's content.

Boundary sentence for the exam. "Both dogmas are positivist commitments before they are Quine's targets, and the essay's force lies in attacking them from **inside** empiricism rather than from outside it."

Supporting part C · 2025 · Q3(a) · 20 marks · owned by Topic 08, Later Wittgenstein

Question: "We should look not to an ideal language which derives its meaning from facts and has a precise 'logical structure but empirically, to the ways in which languages are actually used." Explain the transition from early views of Wittgenstein to his later views on language and meaning with reference to this statement. □ **Printed wording:** the unmatched opening quotation before **logical structure** is visible in the official English line and is retained.

What this clause contributes. ANALYSIS: One **boundary clause only**. The "ideal language" programme criticised in the quotation is shared by the *Tractatus* and by the Vienna Circle, and the later Wittgenstein's refusal of any single criterion of meaning pressures verificationism's uniformity as well as the picture theory's. This clause may note that the Circle's verification criterion is one such single criterion, and that it falls under the same objection.

What this clause may not do. WRONG: It may not develop meaning as use, language-games, family resemblance, forms of life or the private-language argument, all of which are Topic 08's owned content and constitute the answer.

Boundary sentence for the exam. "The transition abandons not only the *Tractatus*'s ideal language but the whole assumption, shared by the Vienna Circle, that a single criterion could sort every sentence into the significant and the senseless."

ANALYSIS: These six questions are **original practice** written in UPSC's directive style, two at each mark value. They are not past questions, and their model answers are independent learner practice.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: "The verification principle is a criterion of meaning and not of truth." Examine this claim. **(Answer in about 150 words.)**

Independent model answer

Thesis. The claim is correct, and the whole doctrine depends on it.

The distinction. The principle asks not whether the world is as a sentence says, but whether there is any way the world could be that would make a difference to it. A sentence passes if it is analytic or if some possible experience bears on its truth.

The decisive illustration. "The earth is flat" is demonstrably false and fully meaningful, because we know exactly what observations settle it. "The Absolute is beyond time" receives no truth-value at all, because no observation is even relevant to it. The first is refuted; the second is disqualified.

Consequence. ANALYSIS: Because the verdict falls on the sentence rather than the object, the positivist may not add that the Absolute does not exist - a denial would need the very truth-conditions he says are missing.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Meaning, not truth: the criterion is a test of candidacy, and mistaking it for a test of truth destroys both halves of the doctrine.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: Comment on the claim that Wittgenstein's *Tractatus* is a verificationist work. **(Answer in about 150 words.)**

Independent model answer

Thesis. The claim is false, and the reason for its falsity explains the whole of logical positivism.

What is true in it. The Circle read the *Tractatus* aloud in 1926-27, its influence on the 1929 manifesto is explicit, and Wittgenstein's conversations with Schlick and Waismann in 1929-32 do contain verificationist formulations.

Why the claim is nevertheless false. The *Tractatus* grounds sense in **bipolarity** and **truth-conditions**: a proposition has sense because it depicts a possible situation. Whether anyone could check that situation is a further and, for the book, irrelevant question. The Circle substituted **verification-conditions** for truth-conditions, converting a logical requirement into an epistemic one.

Why the substitution matters. ANALYSIS: Universal laws have specifiable truth-conditions but no finite conclusive verification-conditions, so the substitution is exactly what generates the strong/weak dilemma.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Wittgenstein was never a member of the Circle, and the criterion that made positivism distinctive is the one thing the Circle did not inherit from him.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: Discuss the linguistic theory of necessary propositions and assess whether it succeeds in reconciling empiricism with the necessity of logic and mathematics. **(Answer in about 250 words.)**

Independent model answer

Thesis. The linguistic theory reconciles empiricism with necessity by a genuine strategy rather than a concession, but the reconciliation is purchased at a price that later criticism showed to be steep.

The problem. Logic and mathematics are necessary, known a priori and certain, whereas empiricism holds that all knowledge derives from experience. Kant answered by making such truths synthetic a priori; Mill by making them empirical generalisations.

The positivist answer. Necessary propositions are **analytic**: true solely in virtue of the meanings and conventions governing their symbols. They are tautologies and give no information about the world. This yields all three properties from one source - necessary because nothing could count against them, a priori because grasping the meanings

suffices, and certain because denial is self-contradiction - while the emptiness that secures them is exactly what an empiricist can afford.

Why the rivals fail. Kant requires a third class the positivists deny. Mill is refuted by two observations: we do not discover " $2 + 2 = 4$ " by counting pebbles, and no experience could refute it, since an apparent counter-instance is attributed to miscounting rather than to arithmetic.

Assessment. ANALYSIS: The account must still explain why an empty discipline is indispensable to physics, and the available reply - that applicability belongs to the embedding empirical theory - is defensible rather than decisive.

CAUTION: Quine argues in "Truth by Convention" (1936) that conventions cannot generate their consequences without presupposing logic, and in "Two Dogmas" (1951) that analyticity cannot be non-circularly defined.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The reconciliation succeeds on its own terms and fails on Quine's; it is the best empiricist account of necessity available before the category of analyticity was itself put in question.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: Examine the protocol-sentence debate and assess its significance for the verification theory of meaning. (Answer in about 250 words.)

Independent model answer

Thesis. The protocol-sentence debate is the most damaging objection to logical positivism precisely because it was raised inside the Vienna Circle: the school that made verification the criterion of meaning could not agree on what verification terminates in.

The question. What is the form and status of protocol sentences (*Protokollsätze*) - incorrigible foundations, or ordinary revisable sentences?

Schlick. In "Über das Fundament der Erkenntnis" (1934) the base consists of **affirmations (Konstatierungen)** such as "here now blue", absolutely certain because understanding the sentence and verifying it are one and the same act. ANALYSIS: Schlick's own catch is fatal: an affirmation cannot be written down and preserved, since recording it yields a hypothesis about a past moment. Its certainty is momentary and unusable.

Neurath. In "Protokollsätze" (1932) protocols are physicalist, observer- and time-indexed, and fallible like any other sentence; "statements are compared with statements, not with 'experiences'". His image is of sailors rebuilding their ship on the open sea.

Carnap. In "Über Protokollsätze" (1932) the **form** of a protocol is not a fact to be discovered but a matter of choice of language - tolerance applied to the Circle's own foundations, which effectively ends foundationalism inside the Circle.

Significance. ANALYSIS: The criterion presupposes that observation-statements are epistemically privileged. Schlick's base is certain but unrecordable, Neurath's is recordable but revisable, and Carnap's is conventional; a chosen base cannot ground a criterion advertised as a discovery about meaning.

Verdict. CAUTION: Schlick's objection that coherence alone admits a consistent fairy-tale is not fully met by Neurath's appeal to encyclopaedic scientific practice, which makes the selection sociological; and the debate moved positivism toward intersubjective, system-level testing without thereby making Quine's later holism a positivist conclusion.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: "Logical positivism failed by its own standards and changed philosophy anyway." Critically examine this assessment of the movement. (Answer in about 350 words.)

Independent model answer

Thesis. Both halves of the assessment are defensible, but only if the failure is described as plural and structural rather than as defeat by a single celebrated objection.

The failure, ranked. ANALYSIS: First, the **strong/weak fork**. Strong verification, requiring conclusive establishment by a finite observation set, excludes universal laws, the past and other minds - it convicts science. Weak verification, requiring only relevance, is so permissive that an auxiliary hypothesis readmits metaphysics. Ayer's 1946 replacement by direct and indirect verifiability was shown by Church in 1949 to admit what it was designed to exclude. ANALYSIS: Second, the **protocol debate** of 1932-35: Schlick's incorrigible affirmations cannot be recorded, Neurath's protocols are revisable, and Carnap's 1932 ruling that their form is a matter of choice ends foundationalism inside the Circle. ANALYSIS: Third, **analyticity and holism**: Quine's "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (1951) attacks the analytic/synthetic

distinction and sentence-by-sentence reductionism together. ANALYSIS: Only fourth comes **self-refutation** - the criterion is neither analytic nor verifiable - and it admits a serviceable reply, that the principle is a proposal or a meta-linguistic rule, whose cost is that a proposal may simply be declined.

What was not a repair. WRONG: Popper's falsifiability is a criterion of scientific **demarcation**, not of meaning, and he held metaphysics to be meaningful. WRONG: The later Wittgenstein abandons any single criterion of meaning whatever, so he pressures the school without supplying its missing formulation.

What changed anyway. ANALYSIS: Schlick's difference-argument (1932) survives as a heuristic of significance: philosophers who reject the criterion still ask what difference a proposed distinction is supposed to make. ANALYSIS: The demand for explicit rules rather than obscurity became a professional norm. ANALYSIS: The agenda of modern philosophy of science and language - confirmation, demarcation, holism, the status of analyticity - is the agenda of positivism's unsolved problems. ANALYSIS: And the separation of criteria of **meaning**, of **truth** and of **scientific status** is a permanent gain that predates none of the school's critics.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The assessment is accurate, provided "failed" names four pressures and not one, and provided "changed philosophy" names a surviving method and agenda rather than a surviving doctrine.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: Compare Ayer's and Carnap's versions of the rejection of metaphysics, and assess which is the more defensible. **(Answer in about 350 words.)**

Independent model answer

Thesis. Ayer's version is a verdict and Carnap's is a reclassification, and the reclassification is the more defensible because it survives objections that the verdict does not.

Ayer's version. In *Language, Truth and Logic* (1936) a metaphysical sentence "purports to express a genuine proposition, but does not". It fails both branches of the criterion of cognitive significance and is therefore a pseudo-statement - not false, but without truth-conditions. ANALYSIS: The strength is clarity and immediate applicability. ANALYSIS: The weakness is dependence: the verdict is only as secure as the criterion, and the criterion is exposed to the strong/weak fork, to Church's 1949 objection and to self-application.

Carnap's earlier version. "The Elimination of Metaphysics through Logical Analysis of Language" (1932) adds what Ayer's verdict lacks - a **diagnosis**. Two routes are distinguished: a term with no empirical criterion of application, and significant terms combined so that no truth-conditions result, the second illustrated by *das Nichts nichtet*, in which a logical quantifier is treated as a name. ANALYSIS: This explains **how** metaphysical sentences are generated rather than merely condemning them.

Carnap's developed version. The principle of tolerance (*Logical Syntax of Language*, 1934/1937, Section 17) holds that "in logic, there are no morals" and demands syntactical rules instead of philosophical arguments; "Empiricism, Semantics, and Ontology" (1950) then separates **internal** questions, settled by a framework's rules, from **external** questions, which are practical proposals about which language to adopt. ANALYSIS: Classical ontological disputes are re-described as disguised proposals about vocabulary.

Assessment. ANALYSIS: Three advantages favour Carnap. His version explains why metaphysical disputes are interminable, since proposals have no truth-values. It leaves internal ontology fully legitimate rather than abolishing ontology altogether. And it replaces a controversial criterion of meaning with a checkable demand for explicit syntactical rules. CAUTION: Its cost is a dependence on the analytic/synthetic boundary that Quine contests, though the Carnapian reply - that pragmatic framework choice need not itself be an analytic truth - remains available.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Carnap's is the more defensible version: tolerance refines anti-metaphysics rather than repeating it, and Quine pressures, but does not by assertion settle, the boundary on which that refinement depends.